

US-GCC update

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US-GCC update

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Arab Gulf states' confidence in President Donald Trump's ability to conclude the Iran war on acceptable terms is eroding, even as Trump sought to assure them at the UN General Assembly that the US is winning but that their patience is required for US sanctions to produce results.

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The US-Saudi relationship is approaching a crisis point because Houthi attacks on Riyadh and Mecca, along with US reluctance to engage militarily in Yemen, will likely accelerate Saudi hedging away from Washington, while the F-35 deal amounts to damage control and will take years to materialize fully.

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The shuttle service through Hormuz is giving Trump some breathing room with Gulf partners because more oil is getting out, but the arrangement is uneven, unsustainable, and not a long-term solution to the disruption of commercial shipping chokepoints in the region.

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Trump's UNGA Meeting with GCC: No New Ground Broken

Trump's meeting on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) with GCC leaders—joined by Turkey, Lebanon, Jordan, and Iraq—produced little of substance. The primary US message was that the military campaign against Iran is succeeding and that the sanctions pressure campaign will require a few more months, particularly until after the US midterm elections, to

meaningfully affect Iranian policymaking.

GCC leaders were reportedly surprised by the lack of new commitments by the US president. Trump asked for more time and patience; while cautious not to push back on Trump publicly, Gulf leaders are quietly signaling a desire for a negotiated compromise with Iran. Indirect US-Iran talks took place on the sidelines at the Qatari mission to the UN, consistent with Qatari mediation efforts reported in the region two weeks prior.

The Shuttle Service: Breathing Room, Not a Long-term Solution

The Hormuz shuttle service is providing Trump political cover with GCC partners, but its benefits are unevenly distributed. The UAE has returned to near pre-war crude export levels. The Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) expanded its tanker fleet, deployed UAE special forces aboard vessels equipped with Ukrainian anti-drone systems (reportedly 300,000–400,000 rounds purchased) and is providing air cover with its own jets together with US naval escorts. Saudi Arabia is looking to copy this model and is already loading significantly more oil through the Persian Gulf as it works to resume Red Sea exports.

Qatar's large LNG tankers cannot easily navigate Omani waters; the UAE has been assisting with smaller vessels, though volumes remain limited. The east-west pipeline remains largely offline, though loading at the Red Sea port of Yanbu may be resuming. Jebel Ali—the region's largest port—remains largely shuttered, with significant economic impact on Dubai and regional trade. Refined product supply constraints are flagged as a watch item heading into winter.

Saudi Arabia: Relationship Under Structural Stress

The US-Saudi relationship is described as approaching crisis levels. Houthi attacks have struck not only Riyadh and the airport but also areas near the holy city of Mecca, while Washington has effectively signaled an informal accommodation with the Houthis—declining to intervene militarily and framing the conflict as a Saudi-Yemeni bilateral problem. The US is, however, providing Saudi Arabia with battlefield intelligence, ammunition, and could still step up its role in defending the kingdom.

The State Department's formal notification to Congress of a proposed sale of 48 F-35 stealth fighter jets at a total package price of approximately \$24.5 billion is read in Riyadh as an attempt to repair a relationship that is already strained. Delivery is unlikely before 2030 given production backlogs, and there is active debate in Riyadh about whether F-35s are even the right platform for the kingdom, with upgraded F-15s considered potentially sufficient for Yemen and future challenges.

The deeper concern is structural: Saudi officials are engaged in a more serious conversation about the value of the US relationship than at any prior point, including past friction across several administrations, such as over the Iran nuclear deal in 2015, the Abqaiq attack in 2019, and the China-brokered Iran-Saudi détente in 2023.

Saudi Arabia is likely to accelerate its diversification away from the US under current conditions. A Saudi-Houthi deal facilitated by Iran is not expected in 2026 but is assessed as increasingly likely heading into 2027, as Houthi battlefield success has inflated their demands to levels—including 70% of oil revenues and lifting all air restrictions—that Riyadh currently finds unacceptable.

US Strategic Direction: Retrenchment while Enabling GCC Partners

The Trump administration's longer-term regional strategy focuses on shifting the burden of US forces and reducing force posture by selling weapons to Middle East allies and serving as an integrator amongst them—including a recently reported CENTCOM-hosted meeting in Europe that brought together GCC and Israeli military leaders. The administration believes it can sustain productive GCC relationships while retrenching.

The US may not be able to pull this off and has a pattern of overestimating its leverage with partner nations. The direction of travel—pushing allies toward self-sufficiency—is assessed as likely to outlast the Trump administration; a future Democratic administration is not expected to reverse course toward large-scale regional military interventionism.

Longer-term US Retrenchment will Contribute to Regional Fragmentation

US retrenchment is accelerating the formation of two competing regional coalitions rather than the integrated security architecture Washington seeks. The "Abraham Coalition"—which includes Israel, UAE, India, Greece—is doubling down on the US security umbrella while diversifying defense relationships toward the UK, France, South Korea, and Ukraine. The "Islamic Coalition"—centered on Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Pakistan—maintains a détente with Iran and is more likely to reach beyond the US umbrella, even toward China, particularly in AI, defense, and other sensitive sectors. Competition between the Abraham and Islamic coalitions in the Levant, Eastern Mediterranean, North Africa, and the Horn of Africa, is a parallel fault line that extends into divisions within the Trump administration itself. The Saudi-UAE rivalry is assessed as both personal—reflecting differences between the two countries' leaders—and structural, given divergent positions on Iran and Israel.

Gulf investment pledges of trillions of dollars from Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Qatar are now assessed as significantly less likely to materialize, with capital being redirected internally toward economic revitalization and infrastructure diversification away from Hormuz dependence.

US civil nuclear cooperation with Saudi Arabia remains explicitly contingent on controls on uranium enrichment and progress toward normalization with Israel. Saudi-Israeli normalization is assessed as very unlikely in the near term; if Trump pushes hard post-Israeli elections (scheduled for 27 October), it will add further pressure to the bilateral relationship (see: 2026 Israeli Election Update , 17 September 2026).

Key Watch Items

1.

Iran deal timeline: Whether Trump can secure a negotiated outcome that reopens Hormuz on terms acceptable to the GCC—the single largest determinant of US-GCC trajectory.

2.

US posture in Yemen: Any shift in Trump's willingness to support Saudi offensive or defensive operations, particularly post-midterms, would materially change the direction of the US-Saudi relationship.

3.

Saudi sweeteners: Movement on the US-Saudi civil nuclear joint venture and AI chip approvals are potential near-term signals of US intent to manage Saudi frustration.

4.

Israeli elections (27 October): A change of government is the basecase at 60%; outcome will shape Trump's normalization push, possibly contributing to US-Saudi tensions.

What Clients Are Asking

Trump's ability to manage GCC relationships through retrenchment: Clients pressed on whether the administration appreciates the depth of GCC frustration. The assessment was that the administration is overconfident in its ability to maintain productive relationships while simultaneously reducing its security commitments and imposing conditions on partners.

China's expanding role in the region: Clients asked how China fits into the evolving regional dynamic. The consensus view is that China will act in its own interest—including applying commercial and political leverage selectively, as in the 2023 Saudi-Iran détente—but is not positioned or willing to replace the US as a security provider. The Islamic coalition is assessed as more likely to deepen ties with China in critical sectors; the Abraham Coalition is expected to remain firmly under the US umbrella.

MBS's domestic standing: Clients asked whether the Yemen war and economic pressures threaten MBS's grip on power. The answer was an unambiguous no—MBS has consolidated control over the National Guard and Ministry of Interior, eliminated competing power centers, and remains broadly popular, particularly among Saudi youth (approximately 70% of the population), due to social liberalization under Vision 2030.

Israeli escalation risk against Iran ahead of elections: Assessed at no more than 10% probability. More likely are continued Israeli military actions in Lebanon, Gaza, and Syria—some of which are already occurring daily—framed domestically as part of a strongman electoral narrative. A unilateral Israeli strike on Iran without US coordination would severely damage the already fraying US-Israel relationship.

Iran's negotiating position: Iran is currently demanding US de-escalation first—lifting the blockade, releasing frozen funds, and US acknowledgment of joint Iran-Oman control of the Strait of Hormuz. Without a significant shift in either side's position, indirect talks at the UNGA are unlikely to move beyond the current protracted standoff.

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